5 India and other Countries

Let's revise!

In the last chapter, we studied the United Nations and got to know about its role in peacekeeping. We also got to know that India has always helped the United Nations in this task. In this chapter, we shall take a critical review of India's relations with neighbouring countries. We will also understand India's relations with some faraway nations.

Let's find out...

- With help of the map of South Asia given below, find out India's neighbours, with whom India shares her boundaries.
- Find out which other of our neighbouring countries share boundaries with each other.

India and her Neighbours

India's position in Asia is geographically and politically important.

India and other Countries

Afghanistan, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Nepal, Bhutan, China, Maldives are India's neighbours. The values of equality and mutual respect have a great importance in India's foreign policy. India has established relations with neighbouring countries on the basis of these values. India is the biggest country in the Indian subcontinent. Similarly, India is economically and technologically more advanced. It is thus natural that India has a great influence among the South Asian countries.

India and Pakistan

In 1947 India was partitioned and two independent countries, India and Pakistan, were created.

India-Pakistan : Indo-Pak relations are influenced by three main factors:

(1) Differences in the world views of both the countries

(2) the Kashmir question and

(3) Nuclear rivalry between the two countries

India and Pakistan have totally different world views. In line with the Indian world view, India opposed the military alliances of the Cold War and tried to solve the Indo-Pak conflict bilaterally. The Shimla Agreement of 1972 was based on this principle. On the other hand, Pakistan tried to maintain relations with the Islamic world and China and entered into a military agreement with America.

Pakistan considers Kashmir as the biggest hurdle in establishing relations with India. The first Indo-Pak war took place in 1965 over Kashmir. The Tashkent Agreement was signed in 1966, but nothing much came out of it. Even though the 1971 war was about the creation of Bangladesh, it also had the dimension of the Kashmir problem to it. The Shimla Agreement in1972 provided a new format to the interaction between India and Pakistan. In 1999, there was a conflict between India and Pakistan over the infiltration by Pakistan in the Kargil region. Even today the Kashmir question is the basic cause of conflict between the two countries. The nature of the conflict has changed and this new type of conflict can be described as terrorism.

Both India and Pakistan conducted nuclear tests in 1998 and that gave rise to new concerns in this region. Many countries feel that these two nations should not get locked in nuclear conflict. One more issue in Indo-Pak relations is the border dispute in Sir Creek area.

Both countries have made efforts to establish a dialogue with each other; but considering the way in which Pakistan is supporting terrorists against India and is engineering terrorist activities in India, all efforts at establishing dialogue are proving to be unsuccessful.

India-China : The conflict between India and China is connected to two issues: (1) Border issue and (2) Status of Tibet

The Border dispute between India and China is related to Aksai Chin area and the Macmahon line. China claims that the area south of Aksai Chin and Macmahon line (Arunachal Pradesh) is Chinese Territory. China is not willing to agree that Macmahon Line is an international border. India made several efforts to sort this border dispute by means of dialogue. But it has not met with much success. In 1962 China attacked India.

Tibet was traditionally autonomous. But when China was stepping up its military control in Tibet, Dalai Lama took asylum in India. This issue has been responsible for the conflict between the two countries.

The threat to India's security is increasing due to the friendship between China and Pakistan, supply of weapons from China to Pakistan and also transfer of missile and nuclear weapons technology. The increasing friendship between China and Pakistan and increasing influence of China over India's other neighbours is a cause of concern for India. Even then, India has always made efforts to improve relations with China. A joint executive group has been set up to solve the Sino-Indian border dispute. When the rate of economic growth of both India and China increased, the trade relations between both the countries began to get strengthened. Because of improvement in economic and trade relations between India and China and a series of tripartite talks between Russia, China and India, Sino-Indian relations are improving slowly. Even though the border dispute is not completely resolved, it has taken a back seat and relations in other areas have become more important.

India and other neighbours

Afghanistan : There is a lot of political instability in Afghanistan. The dominance of the terrorist organisation Taliban is responsible for this. India has extended help to bring peace, security and stability, curb violence and establish a democratic government. Similarly, India is also helping Afghanistan in reestablishing communication facilities that have got destroyed due to war, build roads, cooperate in the fields of science and technology and build schools, health facilities and irrigation projects.

Bangladesh : Today's Bangladesh is the erstwhile East Pakistan. When Pakistan was created, it had two parts : West and East Pakistan. There was linguistic difference between them. There were other political conflicts as well. The movement to liberate Bangladesh emerged out of this. This movement tried to free Bangladesh from the dominance of West Pakistan. India helped Bangladesh in its freedom struggle. Bangladesh was formed in 1971. Some treaties were signed between India and Bangladesh about sharing river waters and some regarding the shared border, which put an end to the conflict between them. Now trade relations between the two countries are growing.

Sri Lanka : India has friendly relations with the southern neighbour Sri Lanka. Political instability in Sri Lanka after 1985 was a result of the differences between the Tamils and the Sri Lankan Government. At that time India had sent a peacekeeping force to help the Sri Lankan government. Friendly relations with Sri Lanka are important from the point of view of security in the Indian Ocean.

Nepal : Nepal and Bhutan are landlocked countries surrounded by mountainous terrain. Their boundaries are linked with India and China. The foundation of friendship between India and Nepal was laid with Indo-Nepalese Friendship Treaty in 1950. According to this treaty, Nepalese citizens can not only enter India, but they are also permitted to take up government jobs and carry on trade in India. The year 1990 marked the beginning of Nepal's transition to democracy. Nepal is dependent upon

India for economic progress, basic facilities, food related needs, trade and energy needs. India sent a lot of help to Nepal at the time of the 2015 earthquake.

Bhutan : India bears the responsibility of the defence of Bhutan. Bhutan has a huge source of water. India has cooperated in the project to produce hydel power on a large scale using this source.

Myanmar : Myanmar is India's door to the South East Asian countries. South Asia, Middle Asia and South East Asia will be connected with each other with the rail and roadways that are being developed in this area. This will help increase trade and other exchange in this region. India will be able to import natural gas from Myanmar.

Do you know?

Myanmar and Aung Sang Su Kyi: Aung Sang Su Kyi is credited with having established democracy in Myanmar after a long drawn struggle against the military regime there. She has been awarded the Nobel Peace Prize.

Maldives : India's relations with Maldives have been friendly right from the beginning. This small nation to the South of India is dependent on India for a lot of reasons. Trade relations have been established between the two since 1981. India has helped Maldives in the development of basic facilities or infrastructure, health and communication. From 2006 onwards, cooperation in the military field also started between the two countries. They have entered into treaties with respect to cooperation in space research, conservation of historical objects and tourism. Similarly they have decided to cooperate in the area of fighting against terrorism.

India and America

India and America are two powerful nations who have democratic political systems. Right from the beginning, America was India's most important trading partner. Many Indians went to

South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation :

SAARC is a regional organisation established by the South Asian countries in 1985. The aim of this organisation is to encourage economic cooperation between South Asian nations and thereby achieve the development of the South Asian region. The organisation of SAARC is a platform for South Asian countries to come together and discuss common questions and interests. Some common interests of South Asian countries are alleviation of poverty, development of agriculture and technological revolution. Some treaties were signed on the SAARC platform to make it easy for South Asian countries to trade with each other. As a part of this, it has been decided that South Asia should be made into a free trade area. For an equitable development of South Asian nations, a treaty about forming South Asian Free Trade Area was signed and South Asian University was established.

* What was the purpose behind establishing the organisation SAARC? * How many member nations are there in SAARC today? * What are the common interests of South Asian Countries?

America for education or work. Due to the presence of these non-resident Indians, the cultural, social and economic relations between America and India have been increasing. After the end of cold war, the military relations between India and America have increased on a large scale. After India accepted free market economy, the speed of economic progress slowly increased. It resulted in further strengthening the trade relations between India and America.

When India conducted nuclear tests in 1998, there was tension in the relations between the two countries. Many rounds of discussions took place after that to improve the relations. Through these rounds of talks, America came to believe that India will use its nuclear weapons with responsibility. This completely transformed the Indo-American relations. The Civil Nuclear Agreement signed in 2005 that was approved by the U.S. Congress in 2008 was an important landmark in Indo-American relations. In the last five years, cordial relations of cooperation in different areas have developed between India and America.

Do you know?

In 2005, the India-U.S. Civil-Nuclear Agreement was signed by Dr. Manmohan Singh, the then Prime Minister of India and George W. Bush Jr. the then American President. In 2008 the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) gave its approval to the deal. Because of this deal, it became possible for India to get nuclear technology from other countries as well.

India and Russia

India and the erstwhile Soviet Russia and Russia of today have always shared friendly relations. In 1971, the Indo-Soviet Treaty of friendship and cooperation was signed between them and it gave great impetus to cooperation between the two countries in defence and technology. The Soviet Russia has also given economic and military help to India on a large scale.

When the Soviet Russia collapsed, India tried to establish relations with Russia. Due to the political and economic problems in Russia, relations did not improve much. After 1996, Indo-Russian relations began to improve slowly. India and Russia have jointly built projects related to production of military equipment, production of mineral oil, etc.

India and European Nations

There are trade relations between European nations and India. Especially Germany and France invest on a large scale in the field of technology in India. Apart from this India gets the technology of production of weapons from European nations. India is a major exporter in the fields of engineering and information technology. Both have the objective of firmness on free trade. India and European nations are cooperating in other areas as well. Several treaties have been signed in the fields of climate change, clean energy, defence production, disaster management, security of air space and terrorism. This cooperation is very important from the point of view of India's development.

Let's find out...

* When was the European Union established?
* Find out more about the European market and European currency.

India and the Continent of Africa

India has consciously taken steps to build cooperation between India and the continent of Africa. Having close relations with Africa will be beneficial from the point of view of both. Many countries in Africa are developing rapidly. India has shown its readiness to help in the all-round development of African youth. India has also agreed to give economic help and even grants to bring about development in different areas like technology, agriculture, tourism, etc. India's energy needs can be fulfilled by the energy rich countries like Egypt, Nigeria, Angola and Sudan. India is making efforts to increase trade with Africa.

The Summit Conference of India and Africa was held in 2015 and the representatives from all 54 African nations attended it. In this conference, discussions were held on many global issues, for example, climate change, terrorism, piracy, etc.

India and the Indo-Pacific area

The Indo-Pacific area includes countries like Japan, Australia, New Zealand and the South-east Asian nations. All of these have close trade relations with India. Many companies there have invested in India. Treaties have been signed between India and Australia about social security, extradition of criminals, the mission against smuggling of drugs, terrorism, art and culture. Japan cooperates with India in basic facilities, economic cooperation, information technology, atomic energy and railways. Japan has agreed to extend cooperation and technological help to India in the development and security of coastal areas. Joint naval exercises are carried out between the navies and coast guards of both the countries.

India and South East Asia

India has had very cordial relations with South-east Asian nations like Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, Philippines, Thailand, Myanmar, Vietnam, Laos, Cambodia and Brunei. After 1991 India changed its economic policy and adopted a free market economy. After that, the trade relations with South-east Asian nations have grown. The policy of increasing trade with South-east Asian nations is known as the 'Look East' policy. After 2014, this policy was made further more active. It is nowadays known as the 'Act East' policy.

India and West Asia : The West Asian countries are primarily suppliers of mineral oil and natural gas. India has traditionally had relations with these countries. India depends upon the mineral oil coming in from west Asia. India imports mineral oil from Iran, Iraq, Baharein, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia and United Arab Emirates. We get modern technology for agriculture and defence equipment from Israel. Also, many Indians live in Israel for their jobs or businesses. They also make a major contribution to our economy.

The main objective of India's foreign policy is to maintain friendly relations with all nations and help each other so as to bring about development of India as well as other nations.

We have taken stock of India's relations with the main countries in the world. In the next chapter, we shall study some important international or global issues.

Exercises

1. Choose the correct option from the given options and complete the statements.

(1) The country that has a free international border with India –
(a) Pakistan (b) Bangladesh
(c) Nepal (d) Myanmar

(2) The countries that have tensed relations with India –
(a) Pakistan and China.
(b) Nepal and Bhutan
(c) Myanmar and Maldives
(d) Afghanistan and America.

(3) Factors that have an influence on the relations between India and Pakistan –
(a) Difference in the world view of both the countries.
(b) Kashmir issue
(c) Nuclear Rivalry
(d) All of the above

2. State whether the following statements are true or false. Give reasons for your answer.

(1) India has an important position among the South Asian countries.
(2) Sino-Indian relations are friendly.
(3) India sent a peacekeeping force to help the Sri Lankan government.

3. Complete the following chart.

No.	Treatise/Exchanges	Countries
1.	.....	India-Pak
2.	Macmahon Line	.....
3.	.....	India-Bangladesh
4.	Import of natural gas	.....
5.	.....	India-America
6.	Infrastructure development, communication, health	.....
7.	.....	India-Africa

4. Explain the following concepts.

(1) Shimla Agreement
(2) Indo-Nepalese friendship treaty
(3) Macmahon Line
(4) Indo-Afghanistan Relations

5. Answer in brief.

(1) Explain the background of cooperative relations between India and America.
(2) Give some information about the efforts taken by India for the establishment of democracy in neighbouring countries with examples.
(3) What is the role of South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation?

Projects

(1) Obtain some information about the foreign tours of the President and the Prime Minister.
(2) Find out about 'Youth Exchange' programmes of different countries.

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